REQUIRED LISTENING:

The Art of Passing Down the Bangers

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TO MY SON,

I put this guide together for us. A lil roadmap through the artists who raised me, inspired me, and pushed me to dig deeper into the sounds that came before my time. I started building this when you were three, already playing these voices around you, letting the melodies settle in your world before you even knew the names.

By the time you're old enough to read this, you'll already have your own taste, your own gems, your own sonic universe. I hope my love for Hip-Hop and R&B helped spark that curiosity.

And because I ain't never been a gatekeeper, I'm sharing this with any parent who wants their kids to grow up knowing real music and the impact it carries.

A NOTE ON THIS GUIDE

This guide wasn't built to chase what's new. It was built to pass down what lasted.

The goal is simple: preserve the songs that still move people, even after the moment, the rollout, or the spotlight has faded. Some of the artists in this volume are less active now. Some are no longer with us. That doesn't weaken the music. If anything, it clarifies what the music actually was — something that could survive being passed down.

Music is subjective. Always has been. This guide isn't the official law of Hip-Hop and R&B, and it isn't trying to be. It's one perspective, shaped by lived experience, cultural memory, and an intentional focus on songs that proved they could outlast their moment. Disagreeing is allowed. Arguing is part of the culture. The only real rule here is to listen with curiosity.

We also pause here to acknowledge the passings of Takeoff and Mac Miller, two artists whose work continues to resonate well beyond their time. Their absence is felt. Their music is still active, still influential, still alive in the spaces where people press play. This guide treats their contributions with respect — not nostalgia — and recognizes that impact doesn't end when output does.

Think of this not as a syllabus carved in stone, but as a crate left open. Take what speaks to you. Question what doesn't. Add your own records when the time feels right. That's how this music has always moved forward.

INTRO

This guide is meant to be used, not studied in silence. There are no quizzes, no right answers, and no expectation that a child understand everything right away. The purpose is exposure. Play the songs. Let them sit in the background. Let kids ask questions. Let them ignore it sometimes. Music works on its own timeline.

Each artist section is built around a single passed-down track and a short explanation of why that music still matters. For younger kids, the song is enough. Movement, melody, repetition, and feeling do the teaching long before words do. The end of each section includes more toddler-friendly bangers for a little variety. For older kids, the short readings offer conversation starters, not conclusions. If a child disagrees, that's not a problem. That's the lesson working.

Adults using this guide don't need to be experts. You don't have to explain eras, sales numbers, or cultural debates unless a child asks. The best use of this guide is casual and consistent. Play the music in the car. Put it on during clean-up. Let it run while drawing, building, or winding down. Over time, familiarity turns into curiosity.

Some songs may raise questions about language, emotion, or behavior. Use those moments to talk, not to lecture. This guide assumes adult discretion and encourages context over censorship. Skipping a song, pausing a track, or revisiting it later is part of the process. There is no penalty for adjusting the pace.

Most importantly, this guide invites participation. Encourage kids to name what they like, what they don't, and what makes them feel something. Let them compare sounds. Let them pick favorites. Eventually, let them add their own songs to the crate. That act of choosing is where cultural literacy actually begins.

> **This guide doesn't aim to define Hip-Hop and R&B for the next generation. It simply opens the door and plays the music loud enough for them to walk in when they're ready.**

We're not archiving careers.

We're passing down bangers like family recipes. Somebody might be inactive. Cool. The song still alive. Somebody fell off. So what. The record didn't.

Kids don't care about Billboard timelines or thinkpieces. They care if it knocks.

A kid hearing "Crank That," "Irreplaceable," or "In Da Club" don't need context. The body understands first. History comes later.

That's real education.

> Soulja Boy, Bow Wow: first internet-native bangers. Period.
>
> Chief Keef, Migos: whole flows and cultures spawned off them.
>
> 50 Cent, Beyoncé, Chris Brown, Rihanna: timeless pop dominance. You still hear these at cookouts, weddings, Target, everywhere.
>
> Frank Ocean, Mac Miller: emotional bangers. Quieter, but they age like wine.

Lowkey, an artist being less active is a feature, not a bug. It removes hype bias. It forces the music to stand on its own. It turns songs into reference points, not distractions.

CONTENTS

Unit 1 — CHIEF KEEF
Unit 2 — RIHANNA
Unit 3 — MIGOS
Unit 4 — MAC MILLER
Unit 5 — FRANK OCEAN
Unit 6 — SOULJA BOY
Unit 7 — BOW WOW
Unit 8 — CHRIS BROWN
Unit 9 — 50 CENT
Unit 10 — BEYONCÉ

UNIT 1

CHIEF KEEF

Chief Keef still matters because he broke the rules and everybody kept the pieces. His sound wasn't polished, his lyrics weren't polite, and the industry didn't know what to do with him, but the kids did. He helped drag hip-hop into the internet age where raw emotion, regional slang, and DIY visuals mattered more than radio approval. You can draw a straight line from his music to today's rap flows, aesthetics, and attitudes. Even if he ain't chart-chasing anymore, the culture still talking in his accent.

PASSED DOWN TRACK

"Love Sosa"

This is the ignition switch. Raw, loud, unpolished, and impossible to ignore. Even if a kid don't understand the words yet, they feel the energy. This record didn't just make noise, it rewired the sound of rap.

TODDLER-FRIENDLY CHIEF KEEF

(CLEAN, SAFE OPTIONS)

- **"Love Sosa" instrumental**
- **"Earned It" (clean)**
- **"Everyday" (clean)**
- **"Citgo" instrumental**

Still gets the vibe without the violence.

UNIT OVERVIEW

Chief Keef =

the drill originator

the Gen Z influence blueprint

the kid who turned his block into international culture

the dude who rewired rap's sound, flows, attitude, and visual language before he could even drink

Your kid gon' learn:

- what drill is (musically + socially)
- how environment shapes art
- how youth culture reshapes the industry
- minimalism, chanting, and melody in rap
- the Chicago sound ecosystem

– what "impact beyond charts" actually looks like

Sosa is a cultural earthquake, not just music.

LESSON 1

Chicago, 2011–2013, Survival Music

Don't sanitize it; teach the truth gently.

Chicago conditions (then):

- hyper-policing
- systemic neglect
- gang fragmentation

digital-age street culture

kids raising kids

poverty + lack of resources

Explain to your kid:

Drill ain't about "glorifying violence." It's documenting an environment adults ignored.

Play:

- **"John Madden" (clean if needed)**
- **"Everyday" (melodic era intro)**

Ask:

> "What emotions do you hear behind the aggression?"

LESSON 2

The Sound: What Makes Drill Drill

Drill = dark, minor-key synths, heavy 808 slides, triplet hi-hats, aggressive ad-libs, simple repetitive hooks, chant-style delivery, emphasis on energy > bars.

Sosa literally INVENTED the "menacing lullaby" aesthetic.

Study:

- **"Love Sosa"**
- **"I Don't Like"**

Teach:

Sometimes innovation is about FEEL, not complexity.

LESSON 3

The Breakout: "I Don't Like" & Viral Power

This is where TikTok got its entire blueprint.

Key notes:

- one of the first true viral rap explosions
- Kanye remix → national spotlight
- YouTube → distribution

teens → cultural engine

authenticity → brand

This was the beginning of youth-led online rap culture.

LESSON 4

Finally Rich (The Blueprint Album)

A REQUIRED album for modern rap literacy.

Themes:

- survival
- loyalty
- trauma

pressure
rebellion
celebration
neighborhood pride
numbness

Key tracks:

- **"Hate Bein' Sober"**
- **"Love Sosa"**
- **"Don't Like"**
- **"Kay Kay"**

This album influenced every rapper of the next decade.

LESSON 5

The Flow: Melodic Chanting + Controlled Chaos

Sosa's flow innovations:

- monotone chanting
- dragging syllables
- yelling as rhythm

ad-lib conversation
short phrases
hypnotic repetition

Modern rap literally talks like him.

Activity:

Play "Love Sosa" and have your kid identify which lines feel "catchy" even WITHOUT melody.

LESSON 6

The Drill Aesthetic: Videos, Fashion, Energy

Chief Keef invented:

- shirt-off-in-the-living-room rap videos

- gang-in-the-background energy
- camera shaking as style
  performance as raw vibe
  suburban teens cosplaying Chicago
  drill fashion (True Religion jeans, designer belts, dreads era)

Teach:
Image shapes genre almost as much as music.

LESSON 7

Production Revolution: Young Chop & the Chicago Sound

Young Chop:
- built the sonic language
- sliding 808s
- frantic hats
  airy synth pads
  big-room drums

Explain:
Drill started as a SOUND before it became a subculture.

Play:
- ► **"Love Sosa" instrumental**
- ► **"Kobe" instrumental**

LESSON 8

Independence & Influence: Sosa After the Labels

Teach the truth:
- left Interscope young
- built GBE's independent model
- moved to LA
  dropped tons of mixtapes
  produced his own music
  became a recluse but cult-legend

Key tapes:
- ► **Bang 2**
- ► **Almighty So**
- ► **Thot Breaker (melodic pivot!)**
- ► **Dedication**

He influenced rap WHILE being anti-industry.

LESSON 9

The Influence Tree: Sosa is the Father of a Generation

DIRECT Influence:

Lil Uzi Vert (melodic chaos)
Playboi Carti (vibe > bars)
Trippie Redd (aggressive melodies)
21 Savage (deadpan menace)
Polo G (emotional drill)
G Herbo (storytelling drill)
Lil Durk (melodic drill)
King Von (narrative drill)

Nationwide Impact:

- NYC Drill
- UK Drill hybrids
- SoundCloud wave

"mumble rap" stereotypes
rage rap culture

Chief Keef didn't become the future. He MADE it.

LESSON 10

Legacy: Youth Culture as Cultural Power

Chief Keef represents:

- youth ownership of sound
- rejecting polish
- DIY ethos

authenticity
culture shaping the industry, not the other way around
the internet as music infrastructure

Teach:

Adults didn't understand Sosa. But the youth did, and that's why he changed everything.

FINAL PROJECT

Explain how Chief Keef helped create drill music through raw storytelling, hypnotic delivery, and internet-driven youth culture. Compare ONE early track ('I Don't Like' or 'Love Sosa') with ONE later melodic track ('Kobe' or 'Thot Breaker'). Identify TWO modern rappers whose style clearly traces back to Chief Keef.

UNIT 2

RIHANNA

Rihanna still matters because she made versatility look effortless. She floated between pop, R&B, dancehall, and hip-hop without losing her identity, which taught a whole generation that reinvention is power. Her songs still hit because they're built on feeling first, not trends. Whether she's singing heartbreak, confidence, or pure chaos, the records aged well because the emotions never left. You don't need a new album for her catalog to stay active.

PASSED DOWN TRACK

"Umbrella"

This is when Rihanna became unavoidable. Simple, sticky, emotional, and still effective. You hear it once and you get it. This song taught pop music how to be timeless without trying too hard.

TODDLER-FRIENDLY RIHANNA

(CLEAN, SAFE OPTIONS)

- **"Diamonds"**
- **"Work" (clean)**
- **"Love on the Brain"**
- **"We Found Love"**

Energetic and bright.

UNIT OVERVIEW

Rihanna =

one of the most influential pop stars of the 21st century
the queen of vibe-based music
a master of reinvention: island girl → edgy rebel → pop queen → fashion mogul
Caribbean diaspora ambassador
fashion-forward cultural force
Fenty empire builder
vocal texture that cuts through ANY production
the blueprint for the modern pop superstar who don't chase perfection, she chases feeling

Your kid gon' learn:

- Caribbean rhythms
- pop structure
- sonic evolution

- self-expression
- confidence
- entrepreneurship
- how culture moves through the diaspora

LESSON 1

Barbados Roots, Accent Pride, & Early Breakthrough

Teach identity & representation.

- Born Robyn Rihanna Fenty
- Raised in Barbados → soca, dancehall, reggae influence
- Accent was NEVER erased. She brought the island to global charts
  Auditioned for Evan Rogers → Def Jam deal under Jay-Z
  Debut: "Pon de Replay" = Caribbean pop explosion in the U.S.

Play:

► **"Pon de Replay"**

Ask your kid:

> "How does the island energy come through in the drums?"

LESSON 2

Caribbean Girl → Mainstream Pop Star (Music of the Sun, A Girl Like Me)

Themes:

- innocence
- dancehall-lite
- Caribbean party vibes
  sunny melodies

Key Tracks:

► **"If It's Lovin' That You Want"**

► **"SOS" (her first #1)**

Activity:

Point out how she blends American pop with Bajan flavor.

LESSON 3

Reinvention #1: The "Good Girl Gone Bad" Era

This was the album that MADE her.

Traits:

- edgy style
- black hair
- pop-rock influence
  fashion shift
  more assertive persona
  superstar confidence

Key Tracks:

- **"Umbrella"**
- **"Shut Up and Drive"**
- **"Hate That I Love You"**

> "What changed about her energy from earlier?"

LESSON 4

Reinvention #2: Rated R Era (Dark, Vulnerable, Fierce)

After trauma, she delivered a DARK, powerful album.

Themes:

- pain
- defiance
- recovery
- anger
- power reclaiming
- rock & dubstep & pop fusion

Key Tracks:

- **"Russian Roulette"**
- **"Rude Boy"**
- **"Hard"**

> **"Artists process trauma through art. That don't mean we glamorize it."**

LESSON 5

Loud + Talk That Talk: The Pop Dominance Era

Traits:

- radio anthems
- dance-pop
- maximalist hooks
- club hits
- colorful aesthetic
- global superstar appeal

Key Tracks:

- **"Only Girl (In the World)"**
- **"What's My Name?"**
- **"We Found Love"**

Activity:

Break down "We Found Love" → simplicity + emotion = POWER.

LESSON 6

Unapologetic Era: Toxic, Sexy, Emotional Pop-R&B

Themes:

- heartbreak
- chaos
- self-destruction
  lust
  self-worth
  club despair

Key Tracks:

- **"Diamonds"**
- **"Stay"**
- **"Pour It Up"**

> "How can someone sound vulnerable AND confident?"

LESSON 7

ANTI: The Masterpiece

This album is her TRUE artistic statement.

Traits:

- anti-pop structure
- soulful R&B
- experimental rhythms
  vocal freedom
  raw emotion
  Caribbean roots foregrounded
  minimalism + depth

Key Tracks:

- **"Kiss It Better"**
- **"Work"**
- **"Love on the Brain"**
- **"Needed Me"**

Activity:

Bring attention to "Love on the Brain" → old-school soul influence.

This album is BLACK, FREE, and CREATIVE.

LESSON 8

Rihanna the Vocalist: Texture, Emotion, & Signature Tone

Rihanna's voice is:

- nasal with grit

- emotional
- instantly recognizable
  imperfect but expressive
  powerful in belts
  textured in mid-range
  Caribbean inflections intact

Play:

► **"Stay"**

> "What emotion do you hear without knowing the words?"

LESSON 9

The Businesswoman: Fenty Revolution

- Fenty Beauty → inclusive shade range
- Savage X Fenty → body positivity + inclusivity
- Fashion House (LVMH partnership)
  marketing genius
  broke the beauty industry
  went from pop star → billionaire mogul

"Talent gets you in the door. But ownership makes you unstoppable."

LESSON 10

Rihanna's Influence Tree

Direct Influence:

SZA (emotional R&B, vocal texture)
Tinashe
Normani
Tems (mutual Caribbean/African lineage)
Dua Lipa (dance-pop revival)
Shenseea (dancehall crossover)
Doja Cat (genre versatility)

Cultural Influence:

- Caribbean slang normalized in mainstream pop
- inclusive beauty standards
- fashion-forward pop stars
  the "anti-perfectionist vocalist" trend
  vibe-based music

Activity:

Play Tems → then Rihanna → ask: "What connects their vocal energy?"

FINAL PROJECT

Explain how Rihanna blended Caribbean roots, genre reinvention, and emotional authenticity to become a global icon. Compare ONE early track (Pon de Replay) with ONE later track (Work) and list TWO artists influenced by her sound.

UNIT 3

MIGOS

Migos still matter because they changed how rap sounds in your ears and in your mouth. Their flow became the default setting for an entire era, from underground rappers to pop stars trying to borrow sauce. They turned ad-libs into punctuation and repetition into rhythm. Even if the group ain't moving the same now, their influence is baked into modern hip-hop grammar. That's legacy work.

PASSED DOWN TRACK

"Bad and Boujee"

This is group chemistry at full blast. The flow, the repetition, the confidence. It's modern hip-hop structure in its purest form. You hear this and you understand why everybody started rapping like them.

TODDLER-FRIENDLY MIGOS

(CLEAN, SAFE OPTIONS)

- **"Stir Fry"**
- **"Walk It Talk It"**
- **"Narcos" (clean)**
- **"Handsome and Wealthy" (clean)**

High-energy, danceable, minimal content issues.

UNIT OVERVIEW

Migos =

Quavo, Offset, Takeoff
pioneers of the triplet flow (da-da-da / da-da-da cadence)
viral slang creators
ad-lib kings
modern ATL trap architects
group chemistry tighter than a drumline
fashion + drip innovators
cultural icons whose style shaped the 2010s

Your kid gon' learn:

- rhythmic patterns
- group call-and-response
- trap beat structures

- ATL cultural lineage
- collaboration dynamics
- viral marketing & meme culture

Migos = textbook modern rap influence.

LESSON 1

Nawf Atlanta, Family Ties, Early Grind

Background:

- From Lawrenceville, GA
- Quavo = Takeoff's uncle
- Offset = Quavo's cousin

  Grew up together → built natural chemistry

  Early mixtape days: Juug Season (2011), No Label (2012)

  Zaytoven, Metro Boomin, DJ Durel played huge production roles

Play:

► **"Bando"**

> "What energy do you hear? Hungry? Fast? Raw?"

LESSON 2

Know Your Roll

Migos ain't three dudes rapping the same way. That'd be noise. They're a system.

Takeoff =

- fastest, cleanest flow
- punchline-heavy
- the "rapper-rapper" of the trio

  technical heartbeat of the group

Quavo =

- melodic anchor
- hook architect
- tone-setter and vibe controller

  the voice casual listeners recognize first

Offset =

- aggression + energy
- ad-libs that matter
- performance driver

  bridges the gap between melody and bars

Play:

► **"T-Shirt"**

► **"Fight Night"**

Groups fail when everybody wanna be the same guy. Groups win when everybody knows their lane and runs it better than anyone else.

LESSON 3

The Triplet Flow a.k.a. The "Migos Flow"

Triplet flow = 3 syllables per beat count ("Versace, Versace, Versace"). They made it MAINSTREAM.

Break down:

- how they ride the pocket
- how this cadence changed rap forever
- why EVERYBODY started using it

Play:

- **"Versace" (original)**
- **Drake version**

> "How does the triplet rhythm control the whole beat?"

LESSON 4

Ad-Libs as Musical Instruments

Migos ad-libs aren't random. They're structure:

- Quavo = melodic "MHM / Huncho!"
- Offset = sharp "Woo! Yah!"
- Takeoff = deep, fast "Takeoff!"

Ad-libs serve as:

- rhythm fillers
- emphasis markers
- energy boosters

group participation sounds

Activity:

Play "Hannah Montana" and map which ad-libs belong to who.

LESSON 5

Y.R.N. (Young Rich N's): The Breakthrough

This mixtape = CULTURE STARTER.

Themes:

- flashy confidence
- teen rebellion energy
- ATL trap lifestyle

infectious hooks

regional slang going global

Key Tracks:

- **"Versace"**
- **"Hannah Montana"**

► **"Adios"**

Your kid gon' see how SOUND spreads worldwide.

LESSON 6

Migos Production Style: Zaytoven, Metro, Murda Beat

Beat traits:

- fast hi-hats
- booming 808s
- eerie melodies

repetitive minimalism

bouncy snare patterns

Play:

► **"Fight Night"**

> "What instruments or sounds stand out the most?"

LESSON 7

Culture: Their Masterpiece & Cultural Reset

This album changed EVERYTHING.

Themes:

- luxury flexing
- group synergy
- ATL pride

hypnotic hooks

fashion icon era (drip culture)

Key Tracks:

► **"T-Shirt"**

► **"Bad and Boujee"**

► **"Slippery"**

► **"Call Casting"**

Activity:

Break down "T-Shirt" → melody + flow + ad-libs = perfect chemistry.

LESSON 8

Culture II: Mainstream Domination

Traits:

- polished pop-trap
- massive features
- stadium-ready flows

anthem-level production

Key Tracks:

- **"Stir Fry"**
- **"Walk It Talk It"**
- **"Narcos"**

> "What's the difference between early rough Migos and polished pop Migos?"

LESSON 9

Takeoff: Quiet Skill > Loud Presence

Teach that mastery doesn't require attention. Skill speaks on its own.

Takeoff =

- fastest, cleanest flow in Migos
- laser-precise timing
- punchlines stacked without yelling
  never rushed, never sloppy
  rapped like he knew he didn't have to prove nothing

Takeoff wasn't chasing the spotlight. He was holding the foundation down. While others set the mood or turned the energy up, he made sure the bars actually hit.

Key Tracks:

- **"Fight Night"**
- **"T-Shirt"**
- **"Commando"**

Activity:

- breath control
- how he lands the end of bars
- how he don't step on anyone else's lane

LESSON 10

Migos Influence Tree

DIRECT Influence:

Lil Baby
Gunna
Young Thug (mutual influence)
DaBaby
Polo G (early flow era)
Key Glock
YNW Melly
Smokepurpp
Playboi Carti
Trippie Redd

Cultural Influence:

- triplet flow becoming standard
- ad-lib heavy rap
- "drip" fashion movement

viral slang ("wap," "dab," "boujee," "migo flow")

ATL takeover in mainstream music

meme rap aesthetics

Activity:

Play ANY modern trap song and see if your kid can hear: triplets, ad-libs, bounce rhythms, Migos DNA. They'll never un-hear it again.

FINAL PROJECT

Explain how Migos revolutionized modern rap through the triplet flow, ad-lib structure, and Atlanta trap production. Compare ONE early track (Versace) with ONE later track (T-Shirt) and identify TWO modern artists influenced by Migos' sound.

UNIT 4

MAC MILLER

Mac Miller still matters because he grew in public and let the music grow with him. He showed that artists don't have to stay frozen in the version that first got attention. His later work hits different because it's honest, vulnerable, and human in a way kids eventually recognize even if they can't name it yet. His songs age well because they're about self-reflection, not flexing for a moment. That kind of music finds you when you're ready.

PASSED DOWN TRACK

"Dang!"

This one bridges fun and feeling perfectly. It's catchy, it's musical, and it eases kids into Mac's world without the weight hitting too early. A smooth entry point that still ages beautifully.

TODDLER-FRIENDLY MAC MILLER

(CLEAN, SAFE OPTIONS)

- **"Best Day Ever"**
- **"Dang!"**
- **"My Favorite Part"**
- **"Come Back to Earth"**

Soft, safe, peaceful vibes.

UNIT OVERVIEW

Mac Miller =

Emotional-growth rap pioneer
Poster child for artistic evolution in public
Mental health honesty before it was trendy
Bridge between backpack rap and alternative hip-hop
One of the first rappers to fully embrace genre fluidity
Champion of vulnerability in masculinity
A case study in "growth > image"
Proof that longevity comes from honesty, not hype
Cultivated a legacy rooted in connection, not controversy
A reminder that art is a process, not a persona

Your kid gon' learn:

- emotional intelligence

- creative evolution
- mental health awareness
- musicianship basics
- genre-blending
- self-reflection through art
- the difference between popularity and impact
- how growth can be heard, not announced

Mac Miller is a life-lesson unit AND a music unit.

LESSON 1

Pittsburgh Kid → Internet-Era Backpack Rap

Humble beginnings + relatability:

- Born Malcolm McCormick in Pittsburgh
- Started rapping as a teen
- DIY grind with friends

Early internet success (DatPiff, YouTube, blogs)

Music felt accessible and friendly

Fans saw themselves in him

Play:

► **"Nikes on My Feet"**

> "How does sounding 'regular' help people connect?"

LESSON 2

Early Success: Joy, Youth, and Pressure

Explain:

- Blew up young
- Party-rap era success
- Touring nonstop

Expectations piled up fast

Happiness + pressure existing at the same time

Key Tracks:

► **"Kool Aid & Frozen Pizza"**

► **"Donald Trump"**

> "Can success feel heavy even when things look fun?"

LESSON 3

Turning Inward: Growth Starts with Discomfort

- Mac didn't want to stay the "happy frat-rap guy"
- Began reflecting on identity, purpose, and fame
- Music got darker, slower, more introspective

Play:

► **"Thoughts from a Balcony"**

> "Why do artists sometimes change even if fans don't want them to?"

LESSON 4

Watching Movies with the Sound Off: Identity Crisis as Art

Teach:

- Psychedelic sounds
- Messy emotions
- Creative experimentation
  No clean answers on purpose

Key Tracks:

- **"Objects in the Mirror"**
- **"S.D.S."**

Activity:

Ask your kid if the music feels uncomfortable, then explain why that matters.

LESSON 5

Larry Fisherman: Mac as Producer & Musician

- Mac played piano, bass, drums, guitar
- Produced under the name Larry Fisherman
- Loved jazz, soul, funk
  Built songs from emotion first

Play:

- **"Avian"**
- **Run-On Sentences (instrumental excerpts)**

> **"Learning instruments gives artists more control."**

LESSON 6

GO:OD AM: Accountability & Recovery

- Acknowledged addiction struggles
- Focused on balance and awareness
- Honesty without glamorizing pain

Play:

- **"100 Grandkids"**
- **"Perfect Circle / God Speed"**

> "What does trying to do better sound like?"

LESSON 7

The Divine Feminine: Love as Healing

Teach:

- Explores love, respect, intimacy
- Softness instead of bravado
- Romance without ego

Key Tracks:

- **"Dang!"**
- **"My Favorite Part"**

> "How is this different from how rap usually talks about love?"

LESSON 8

Swimming: Mental Health as Sound

Teach self-acceptance:

- Anxiety, depression, patience
- Calm, reflective production
- Letting go of perfection

Play:

- **"Come Back to Earth"**
- **"Self Care"**
- **"2009"**

Activity:

Ask your kid why this album feels like floating instead of sinking.

LESSON 9

Circles / Balloonerism: Closure & Peace

Growth doesn't erase confusion. It builds on it.

Teach:

- Show how artists grow over time
- Teach emotional awareness without glamorizing struggle
- Compare "in-progress thoughts" vs reflection
  Reinforce that growth isn't a straight line

Listening Lab (Side-by-Side):

From Balloonerism:

- **"Funny Papers"**
- **"Do You Have a Destination?"**

From Circles:

- **"Good News"**
- **"Surf"**

Ask while listening:

- Which songs sound restless?
- Which songs sound settled?
- What changed: the sound or the mindset?

Mac Miller teaches us: You don't have to rush becoming yourself. Being in progress is part of the process.

LESSON 10

Mac Miller's Influence Tree

DIRECT / SPIRITUAL Influence:

Juice WRLD
Kid Cudi
Isaiah Rashad
Chance the Rapper
Kota the Friend
Rex Orange County
Jack Harlow (early era)
Logic (vulnerability lane)

Cultural Influence:

- Mental health openness in rap
- Genre-blending
- Producer-rappers

Honest masculinity
Slower, reflective hip-hop

"Growth isn't loud. It's consistent."

FINAL PROJECT

Explain how Mac Miller's music shows emotional growth, artistic evolution, and honesty. Compare ONE early song ('Nikes on My Feet' or 'Kool Aid & Frozen Pizza') with ONE later song ('2009' or 'Good News'). Identify TWO modern artists influenced by Mac Miller's approach.

UNIT 5

FRANK OCEAN

Frank Ocean still matters because he proved silence can be loud. He doesn't chase charts, trends, or attention, yet his music stays in rotation because it speaks to identity, love, and confusion in a way that feels timeless. His songs don't rush you. They sit with you. In a fast-scroll world, that patience is revolutionary. Kids hearing him learn that art doesn't have to shout to be powerful.

PASSED DOWN TRACK

"Thinkin Bout You"

This is emotional clarity in song form. Gentle, honest, unforgettable. It sticks because it's vulnerable without being fragile. A quiet classic that teaches kids music doesn't always have to yell.

TODDLER-FRIENDLY FRANK OCEAN

(CLEAN, SAFE OPTIONS)

- **"Pink + White"**
- **"White Ferrari"**
- **"Ivy"**
- **"Sweet Life"**

Floaty, gentle, calming.

UNIT OVERVIEW

Frank =

The quiet innovator of 2010s R&B
A master of nonlinear storytelling
A poet disguised as a vocalist
A queer Black artist shifting culture with subtlety instead of spectacle
A master of imagery and metaphor
The architect of mood music as high art
A genre-melter blending R&B, folk, ambient, soul, hip-hop, & minimalist pop
The blueprint for introspective male vulnerability

Your kid gon' learn:

- Poetic devices
- Harmonic minimalism
- How to make a "small" voice sound huge emotionally

- Queer history & representation (when they're older)
- Abstract storytelling
- Symbolism
- Patience in listening
- That masculinity can include softness without losing strength

Frank gon give em heart & brain.

LESSON 1

New Orleans, Katrina, Odd Future & The Ghostwriter Era

Teach where Frank came from:

- Born in New Orleans → jazz city
- Hurricane Katrina uprooting him → resilience
- Moved to LA → worked as a songwriter for Justin Bieber, Bey, Brandy

Odd Future era → found creative freedom

Frank as the "quiet assassin" in a wild crew

Listening Lab:

► **"Novacane"**

> "How does Frank make numbness sound beautiful?"

Teaches emotional subtext.

LESSON 2

nostalgia, ULTRA: The Mixtape That Broke the Internet

Teach:

- Lo-fi textures
- Samples used like diary entries
- Nonlinear storytelling

Cinematic imagery

Subtle flexing

Vulnerability behind sarcasm

Cultural commentary

Key Tracks:

► **"We All Try"**

► **"Swim Good"**

► **"Novacane"**

Activity:

Break down "We All Try" → teach optimism vs reality.

LESSON 3

Lyricism: Poetics, Queerness, and Hidden Layers

Frank's tools:

- metaphor-heavy writing
- incomplete narratives
- implied emotion

pronoun ambiguity

ocean/beach/car/weather symbolism

double meanings
heartbreak told sideways instead of directly

Listening Lab:

► **"Bad Religion"**

= unrequited love described as a taxi ride + prayer.

> **"Sometimes art whispers the truth instead of shouting it."**

LESSON 4

Channel Orange: The Masterpiece of Impressionistic R&B

Teach:

– Synesthesia → Frank "sees" songs in colors
– Sonic variety (funk, pop, soul, ambient)
– Character-based storytelling
Queer love revealed softly
Songs written like short films
Themes of addiction, longing, wealth, youth, queerness

Key Tracks:

► **"Thinkin Bout You"**
► **"Pyramids"**
► **"Bad Religion"**
► **"Super Rich Kids"**
► **"Pink Matter"**

Activity:

Break "Pyramids" into its two halves → teach narrative progression.

LESSON 5

Vocals: Technique Isn't Just Belting

Frank's vocal signatures:

– soft tenor
– airy falsetto
– shaky runs ON PURPOSE
talk-singing
emotional tremble
layered harmonies like ghosts
intimate mic proximity

Activity:

Have your kid identify when Frank switches from chest voice → falsetto.

LESSON 6

Queer Representation & Emotional Honesty

- Frank publicly opening up about first love being a man
- Doing so quietly, without spectacle
- Creating safe space in R&B for queer Black boys

  Importance of representation

  Art as vulnerability

  Normalizing emotional expression

> **"Being honest with yourself don't make you weaker. It make you real."**

LESSON 7

Blonde: Minimalism as Spiritual Practice

Blonde =

- Almost no drums
- Guitar & synth atmospheres
- Vocals warped like dreams

  Themes of memory, grief, nostalgia, loneliness

  Influence from The Beatles to Elliott Smith to James Blake

  Songs that feel like floating

Key Tracks:

- **"Nikes"**
- **"Ivy"**
- **"Pink + White"**
- **"Nights"**
- **"White Ferrari"**

Listening Lab:

Break down "Nights" → the beat switch marks a timeline shift in his life.

LESSON 8

Frank's Production Style

Explain:

- layered harmonies
- atmospheric synths
- unconventional song structures

  beat switches

  lo-fi imperfections

  guitars as emotional texture

  distortion used as vulnerability

  ambient music influence

  drums used sparingly for emphasis

Activity:

Let your kid choose any 3 Frank songs & draw how each song "feels." Frank's music is visual.

LESSON 9

Frank's Mystery: The Art of Disappearing

Explain:

- Frank rarely interviews
- Drops music unexpectedly
- Rejects fame's expectations

Keeps his life sacred

Still has huge cultural presence

"You can be great without giving the world every piece of you."

LESSON 10

Frank Ocean's Influence Tree

SZA

The Weeknd (mutual influence)

Tyler, The Creator (emotional growth era)

Brent Faiyaz

Daniel Caesar

Steve Lacy

Khalid

Blood Orange

Omar Apollo

Amaarae

Pinkpantheress (indirect)

Every alt-R&B sad boi on SoundCloud

Activity:

Pick ANY Gen-Z R&B artist → find the Frank DNA.

FINAL PROJECT

Explain how Frank Ocean reshaped R&B through narrative subtlety, minimalism, and emotional vulnerability. Compare ONE Channel Orange song and ONE Blonde song, plus identify ONE modern artist influenced by him.

UNIT 6

SOULJA BOY

Soulja Boy still matters because he figured out the internet before the industry caught up. He showed artists how to market themselves directly to fans, turn dances into records, and turn records into moments. His music wasn't just songs, it was participation. That blueprint is everywhere now. Even if people joke about him, they still using his playbook.

PASSED DOWN TRACK

"Crank That (Soulja Boy)"

There's no skipping this. It's history, participation, and fun in one record. This song changed how music spreads. Kids don't just hear it, they move to it. That's impact.

TODDLER-FRIENDLY SOULJA BOY

(CLEAN, SAFE OPTIONS)

- **"Pretty Boy Swag" (clean)**
- **"Turn My Swag On"**
- **"Kiss Me Thru the Phone"**
- **"Donk"**

Fun, upbeat, kid-proof.

UNIT OVERVIEW

Soulja Boy =

Pioneer of internet rap
Inventor of viral marketing strategies artists STILL use
A digital native long before Gen Z
Hook + dance architect
Meme icon turned respected innovator
One-man production team
Blueprint for DIY artists
Father of ringtone rap (a $2B industry at its peak)
Influenced streaming culture, YouTube culture, and SoundCloud culture
A walking case study in "innovation > respectability"

Your kid gon' learn:

- internet entrepreneurship
- marketing strategy

- beat-making basics
- simplicity in songwriting
- youth culture influence
- the difference between "hype" and "impact"

Soulja Boy is a tech lesson AND a music lesson.

LESSON 1

Batesville → Atlanta → Internet Grind

Early-internet hustle:

- Born DeAndre Way
- Moved to Mississippi
- Started producing as a kid
  Uploaded music to SoundClick, MySpace, YouTube
  Tag manipulation to get discovered
  Built a fanbase BEFORE labels
  First rapper to use the internet as the MAIN platform

Play:

- ► **"I Got Me Some Bapes"**

> "How did he make the internet his neighborhood?"

LESSON 2

Crank That: The First True Viral Song

Virality mechanics:

- DIY beat
- Instructional dance = viral fuel
- YouTube + MySpace era explosion
  Kids sharing videos → early algorithm behavior
  Ringtone era = millions made
  No label needed

Key Elements:

- simple melody
- repeatable hook
- meme-friendly ad-libs
  dance challenge
  entire marketing ecosystem built by KIDS

Activity:

Break down why the beat is SO catchy (808 bounce + steel drum squeak).

LESSON 3

Soulja as Producer: The Young Metro Before Metro

Soulja Boy made:

- ► **"Crank That"**
- ► **"Donk"**
- ► **"Yahhh!"**

- **"Turn My Swag On"**
- **"Pretty Boy Swag"**

Traits:

- catchy lead sounds
- trunk-rattling low-end
- repetitive but effective patterns

DJ-friendly BPM

minimalism = hitmaking

Let your kid hear the stems if possible: show how SIMPLE = VIRAL.

LESSON 4

SouljaBoyTellEm.com: DIY Aesthetic

Themes:

- fun
- teen energy
- self-produced beats

ringtone hooks

dance culture

youth empowerment

Key Tracks:

- **"Soulja Girl"**
- **"Donk"**
- **"Report Card"**

Activity:

Point out how youthful he sounds → his fans WERE his age.

LESSON 5

Marketing Genius: The Blueprint for Modern Promotion

Soulja Boy did:

- cross-platform branding before it was common
- consistent posting
- fan engagement

internet authenticity

merch

dance trends

viral challenges

DIY music videos

algorithms before algorithms

He created: The influencer-rapper model.

> "What online habits today started with Soulja Boy?"

LESSON 6

"Turn My Swag On": The Self-Confidence Anthem

Play:

► **"Turn My Swag On"**

This song became: a meme, motivational quote, TikTok revival, cultural reset moment. Beyoncé even sampled it!

Activity:

Discuss why confidence tracks MATTER for youth.

LESSON 7

The "First Rapper To…" Meme: But Lowkey True

Not jokes. 100% REAL:

- first rapper to blow up off YouTube
- first viral dance
- first to weaponize the internet for fame

first fanbase built fully online

first to treat beats like loops for attention economy

He was the template for:

Chief Keef

Odd Future

SoundCloud era

Lil Nas X

Yachty

Uzi

ANY viral artist today

> **"Innovation gets clowned before it gets celebrated."**

LESSON 8

The SoundCloud → Meme Rap → Trap Connection

Soulja Boy's sound/approach birthed:

Lil B

Riff Raff

Yung Lean

SoundCloud wave (2013–2017)

Lil Pump

Playboi Carti (minimalism)

Uzi (fun + charisma)

Chief Keef (internet-first)

Activity:
Play early Soulja → then play early SoundCloud artists. Ask: "What's the shared DNA?"

LESSON 9

Soulja Boy's Entrepreneurship

Soulja did:

- endorsements
- merch
- online branding

streaming platform attempts
high-volume single strategy
NFT experiments
online direct-to-fan before it was trendy

"You don't need permission to build something."

LESSON 10

Soulja Boy's Influence

DIRECT Influence:

Chief Keef
Lil B
Yung Lean
Lil Yachty
Playboi Carti
Trippie Redd
Lil Uzi Vert
XXXTentacion
Lil Pump
6ix9ine
EVERY TikTok rapper
EVERY dance challenge artist

Technological Influence:

- YouTube rap
- Viral dances
- Internet discovery

DIY music video culture
Meme-driven hits
Streaming-first marketing

Soulja Boy = whole ecosystem.

FINAL PROJECT

Explain how Soulja Boy used the early internet, DIY production, and viral marketing to reshape the music industry. Compare ONE early track (Crank That) with ONE later track (Pretty Boy Swag) and identify TWO modern artists heavily influenced by Soulja Boy's blueprint.

UNIT 7

BOW WOW

Bow Wow still matters because he was proof that kids could see themselves in hip-hop without pretending to be grown. He made rap accessible to younger audiences while still being taken seriously, which wasn't common at the time. His music captured a moment when fun, confidence, and youth ruled the sound. Even if he's not dropping hits now, those records still work because they remind listeners that hip-hop once made space for joy.

PASSED DOWN TRACK

"Like You"

This is youth, confidence, and melody wrapped together. It still sounds good because it wasn't trying to be tough. It was trying to be relatable. That matters when passing music down.

TODDLER-FRIENDLY BOW WOW

(CLEAN, SAFE OPTIONS)

- **"Bounce With Me"**
- **"That's My Name"**
- **"Let Me Hold You"**
- **"Basketball"**

Fun, upbeat, age-appropriate.

UNIT OVERVIEW

Bow Wow =

The first successful child rapper to grow up in real time
Prototype for youth-to-adult transition in hip-hop
Bridge between 90s rap mentorship and 2000s pop rap
Early proof that kids could be the PRIMARY rap audience
Touring, merchandising, and branding at a child scale
A case study in fame before identity fully forms
Pop-rap hitmaker with longevity across eras
Influenced the teen-rap-to-mainstream pipeline

Your kid gon' learn:

- how youth culture drives markets
- artist development over time
- the pressure of early fame

- branding for kids vs adults
- pop rap mechanics
- mentorship in hip-hop
- the difference between legacy and narrative
- how success can still be complicated

Bow Wow is a culture lesson AND a media-literacy lesson.

LESSON 1

Columbus, Ohio → Snoop Dogg → Jermaine Dupri

Mentorship and early discovery:

- Born Shad Moss
- Performing as a kid
- Discovered by Snoop Dogg at age 6

Nicknamed "Lil Bow Wow"

Signed to So So Def under Jermaine Dupri

Raised inside the industry, not adjacent to it

Play:

► **"Bow Wow (That's My Name)"**

> "What happens when talent meets opportunity VERY early?"

LESSON 2

Beware of Dog: The Kid Rap Blueprint

Explain:

- Released at age 13
- Clean, fun, confident rap
- Lyrics kids could repeat

Production sounded grown, but content stayed age-appropriate

Massive commercial success

Key Elements:

- simple flows
- catchy hooks
- adult co-signs (Snoop, JD)

kid relatability

Play:

► **"Bounce With Me"**

► **"That's My Name"**

> "Why was it important that Bow Wow sounded confident but not reckless?"

LESSON 3

Pop Rap Mechanics: Hooks, Features, Accessibility

Bow Wow mastered the pop-rap formula: Features from R&B singers. Simple verses + melodic choruses. Radio-friendly structures.

Key Tracks:

► **"Take Ya Home"**

► **"Like You"**

Activity:

Break down the song structure: Verse → hook → verse → hook → bridge → hook.

LESSON 4

Growing Up in Public: Image vs Reality

Teach identity pressure:

- Transitioning from child star to teen rapper
- Expectations to "be harder"
- Fans aging faster than image shifts

  Public scrutiny at a young age

Play:

► **"Let Me Hold You"**

> "Is it fair to expect kids to grow up on OUR timeline?"

LESSON 5

Wanted Era: Teen Idol Meets Rapper

Teach:

- Became a teen heartthrob
- Balanced rap credibility with pop appeal
- Movies, TV, merch, posters, magazines

  Bow Wow became a BRAND

Key Tracks:

► **"Like You"**

► **"Shortie Like Mine"**

Popularity doesn't cancel talent. It just changes perception.

LESSON 6

Acting & Media Expansion

Teach:

- Like Mike
- Roll Bounce
- Lottery Ticket

  TV appearances, hosting, reality TV later

Play:

► **"Basketball" (from Like Mike)**

> "How does acting help a music career?"

LESSON 7

The Authenticity Debate

Media literacy:

- Bow Wow faced criticism for image shifts
- Internet jokes shaped public narrative
- Social media amplified ridicule

Success doesn't protect from disrespect

Narratives are often louder than facts.

Play:

► **"Fresh Azimiz"**

"Can someone be successful AND misunderstood?"

LESSON 8

Influence on Youth Rap Culture

Bow Wow opened doors for:

Lil Romeo
Mindless Behavior
Diggy Simmons
Tyga (early era)
YBN Nahmir
Iann Dior
Any rapper marketed directly to teens

Kid rap became a lane because Bow Wow proved it could work.

LESSON 9

Longevity Without Reinvention

Teach realistic outcomes:

- Not every artist reinvents successfully
- Some maintain relevance through presence, not charts
- Bow Wow stayed visible across decades

Play:

► **"We In Da Club"**

"Is staying known different from staying hot?"

LESSON 10

Legacy: What Bow Wow Really Represents

Bow Wow represents:

- early fame
- youth culture power
- the cost of growing up famous

pop rap mastery

mentorship lineage
cultural saturation
lessons about identity and timing

You can be successful and still struggle with perception. Both things can be true.

FINAL PROJECT

Explain how Bow Wow shaped youth culture and pop rap through early fame, mentorship, and branding. Compare ONE early song ('That's My Name') with ONE later song ('Like You' or 'Let Me Hold You'). Identify TWO artists who followed the youth-to-mainstream blueprint Bow Wow helped create.

UNIT 8

CHRIS BROWN

Chris Brown still matters because talent doesn't expire. His catalog is stacked with songs that blend melody, rhythm, and movement in a way few artists can match. Strip away the headlines and the music still connects because it's built for feeling and motion. His influence on modern R&B and pop performance is undeniable. Kids hear the songs before they ever learn the context, and the records still do their job.

PASSED DOWN TRACK

"Forever"

This is motion music. Clean, upbeat, and universally understood. Strip away the noise and this song still works in any room, any age group. That's staying power.

TODDLER-FRIENDLY CHRIS BROWN

(CLEAN, SAFE OPTIONS)

- **"With You"**
- **"Fine China"**
- **"Don't Wake Me Up"**
- **"Next to You"**

Upbeat, melodic, safe.

UNIT OVERVIEW

Chris Brown =

A prodigy vocalist AND dancer

One of the most consistent hitmakers of the 2000s–2020s

The most MJ-influenced performer without being a copy

A master of R&B melodies, pop hooks, and choreography

A polarizing figure who teaches real-life lessons about accountability, consequences, and growth

A blueprint for modern R&B/Pop hybrid artists

Your kid gon' learn:

- Performance technique
- Vocal agility
- Choreography structure
- Pop-R&B evolution
- Creative reinvention

- Fame pressures & consequences
- How to critique art AND behavior responsibly

LESSON 1

The Prodigy Era: Young Chris Appears

Understand how CB entered the game:

- Born in small-town Virginia
- Self-taught dancer (MJ, Usher, Ginuwine influence)
- Signed at 15

Debut album produced by the top R&B minds

"Run It!" going #1 made him the first male artist since Diddy to do so with a debut single

Key Tracks:

- **"Run It!"**
- **"Yo (Excuse Me Miss)"**
- **"Say Goodbye"**

Activity:

Show him the "Run It!" choreography. Ask: "What makes him look confident even as a kid?"

LESSON 2

The Dancer: Chris as a Choreography Architect

Teach dance-musicality:

- Pops, glides, MJ-inspired footwork
- Use of upper-body isolation
- Fast-slow dynamic (speed shifts)

Storytelling through movement

Stunt choreography ("Beautiful People," "Turn Up the Music")

Modern TikTok choreography roots trace back to CB

Watching Lab:

- **"Take You Down" live performance**
- **"Fine China" (Mafia-style dance sequence)**
- **BET Awards Tribute Performances**

"How does he make dancing look EASY?"

LESSON 3

Vocals: The CB Sound

His vocal strengths:

- Light, bright tenor
- Agile runs
- Falsetto control

Pop-friendly diction

R&B melisma without overdoing it

How he layers harmonies for depth

Listening Lab:

- **"No Air"**
- **"With You"**
- **"Back to Sleep"**

Activity:

Have him identify: chest voice, head voice, falsetto, riff vs run. Good intro to vocal theory.

LESSON 4

Exclusive / Graffiti Era: Pop Crossover

Teach the transition to pop superstar:

- Synth-heavy production
- Big choruses
- High-energy dance tracks

Collabs with rappers (foundation of his dual-genre identity)

Key Tracks:

- **"Kiss Kiss"**
- **"Forever"**
- **"Wall to Wall"**

"How do these songs feel different from his early R&B?"

LESSON 5

The Controversy: What We Do With Hard Truths

Teach real-life moral lessons with clarity, not avoidance.

Some music comes attached to behavior that can't be ignored. Chris Brown is one of the clearest examples of that tension — and one of the most useful ones to work through.

The facts:

- 2009 assault on Rihanna, a person featured in this same guide
- Public backlash, industry consequences — and significant industry protection
- Pattern of legal and behavioral issues across the years since

A catalog that kept growing and kept connecting with audiences anyway

That last part is the real lesson. Not that harm is forgivable because the music is good. The lesson is that culture often rewards talent regardless of behavior, and your child needs to be able to name that when they see it.

Don't wait until they're "old enough." They're already watching how adults navigate it.

A position worth taking:

Admiring what someone can do and holding them accountable for what they did are not opposites. Kids can handle both. What they can't handle — long-term — is adults who model silence or contradiction around people they admire.

Discussion:

> "The music didn't change. But knowing what we know — does it feel different? Should it? Why or why not?"

That's not a trick question. There's no clean answer. But sitting with it is where the thinking starts.

LESSON 6

F.A.M.E. / Fortune: The Comeback Blueprint

Show how CB re-entered the mainstream:

- Huge singles
- Dance-first promotional strategy
- Reinforcing R&B core

A mix of radio-friendly & edgy tracks

Strategic collaborations

Key Tracks:

- **"Look at Me Now"**
- **"Deuces"**
- **"Yeah 3x"**
- **"She Ain't You"**

Activity:

Break down the flow switch on "Look At Me Now." His verse is underrated technically.

LESSON 7

CB the Hit Factory: Hooks, Hooks, Hooks

Teach his hook formula:

- Repetition → catchiness
- Rising melodic lines → emotional lift
- Layered harmonies → fullness

Call-and-response energy

Simple words, complex melodies

Key Tracks:

- **"Loyal"**
- **"Heat"**
- **"No Guidance"**
- **"Privacy"**
- **"Fine China"**

Activity:

Have your kid rewrite a hook in CB-style simplicity.

LESSON 8

Mixed-Genre Master: R&B, Pop, Trap, Dancehall, Afrobeats

Showcase versatility:

- Trap&B (early adopter)
- Caribbean-inspired hits
- Afrobeats integrations

EDM-pop era

Smooth R&B ballads

Rap-singing fusion

Listening Lab:

- **"Questions" (dancehall)**
- **"Under the Influence" (R&B/trap)**
- **"Fine China" (MJ funk homage)**

> "What genre does this SOUND like? And why does it still sound 'Chris Brown'?"

LESSON 9

Choreography-Driven Visuals

Watch:

- **"Fine China"**
- **"Don't Wake Me Up"**
- **"New Flame"**
- **"Turn Up the Music"**

Discuss:

- Color palettes
- Movement pacing
- Camera angles built around choreography

Narrative elements

Film influences

CB's videos teach your kid how visual storytelling works.

LESSON 10

Chris Brown's Influence Tree

Influenced by Chris:

Usher's later styles (mutual shift)

Jason Derulo

Jacob Latimore

Tory Lanez

August Alsina
Bryson Tiller (melodic hybrid)
Ayo & Teo
Ne-Yo's dance direction
K-pop choreography & vocal styling inspiration
Every R&B/trap hybrid singer of the 2010s+

Activity:

Pick any modern R&B male performer → find the CB DNA.

FINAL PROJECT

Analyze Chris Brown as a performer and vocalist. Then explain how his career became one of the clearest examples of how the music industry handles accountability — and how audiences make their own decisions separate from the industry's.

Require:

- 2 songs (one early, one after 2011)
- 1 choreography breakdown — what specifically makes his movement distinctive
- 1 vocal analysis — runs, register, what he does better than most
- 1 honest response — not a verdict, but a position. What do you do with an artist whose art moves you and whose behavior caused harm? Write it out.

The point isn't to arrive at the "right answer." The point is to practice thinking about something complicated without shutting it down.

UNIT 9

50 CENT

50 Cent still matters because he mastered the art of impact. His music taught lessons about confidence, survival, and branding all at once. Those early records still knock because they were simple, direct, and fearless. He also showed how an artist could turn momentum into business, which is just as important as the songs themselves. Even inactive as a rapper, his blueprint still gets studied.

PASSED DOWN TRACK

"In Da Club"

This is dominance in audio form. Simple hook, undeniable rhythm, instant recognition. It still hits because it was built to last. Every generation knows this one whether they want to or not.

TODDLER-FRIENDLY 50 CENT

(CLEAN, SAFE OPTIONS)

- **"In Da Club" (instrumental)**
- **"Window Shopper" (clean sections)**
- **"Just a Lil Bit" (clean)**
- **"21 Questions" (clean)**

They'll bop without the rated-R extras.

UNIT OVERVIEW

50 Cent =

The most impactful rap debut since Snoop
A master of character, conflict, and marketing
The man who weaponized mixtapes
Hook-writing genius ("In Da Club," "21 Questions," "Many Men," "Candy Shop")
Ruthless storyteller whose life is the brand
Mogul who turned rap success into TV, film, liquor, and multimedia empires

Your kid gon' learn:

- Branding through narrative
- Song structure
- Street-to-boardroom evolution
- The role of controversy in hip-hop history
- How work ethic + strategy beat talent alone

– How ONE album can shift a whole coast

LESSON 1

Queens, Hustling, and Bulletproof Narrative

The environment that shaped him:

- Southside Jamaica, Queens
- Mother's death → raised by grandparents
- Early hustling → street education

Getting shot 9 times

The "mythic narrative" that made him bulletproof (literally & figuratively)

How authenticity shaped his entire persona

Listening Lab:

- **"How to Rob"**

> "How does humor + threat make people pay attention?"

LESSON 2

Mentorhood: Eminem & Dr. Dre Partnership

How cosigns work at the highest level:

- Eminem signs 50 → credibility boost
- Dr. Dre → production muscle
- Interscope → industry machine

Why this co-sign was the most powerful of its era

The idea of "mentorship as leverage"

Activity:

Play "Patiently Waiting." Break down how Em frames 50's origin story.

LESSON 3

Mixtape Reign: Why 50 Changed the Whole Game

How 50 weaponized the mixtape format:

- 50 remixed EVERYBODY's songs and outperformed the originals
- Flooding the streets → free promo
- G-Unit mixtapes became the blueprint

Mixtape presence → anticipation for Get Rich or Die Tryin'

How 50 basically invented modern mixtape marketing

Key Mixtapes:

- **50 Cent Is the Future**
- **Guess Who's Back?**
- **No Mercy, No Fear**

Activity:

Have your kid compare an original track to 50's remix. Ask: "Why does his version feel more alive?"

LESSON 4

Get Rich or Die Tryin': The Nuclear Debut

Treat this album like a historical document:

- One of the most dominant debut albums ever
- Street anthems + pop smashes = versatility
- Hook mastery

  Dre's cinematic production

  50's monotone menace delivery

  Pain wrapped in cockiness

Key Tracks:

- **"In Da Club"**
- **"Many Men"**
- **"If I Can't"**
- **"P.I.M.P."**
- **"21 Questions"**

Activity:

Break down "Many Men" as a storytelling piece. Your kid gon' learn pain → art transformation.

LESSON 5

Hook Writing: 50's Secret Weapon

His hook traits:

- Simple phrases
- Catchy melodies
- Repetitive but not boring

  Emotion baked in (even the aggressive ones)

  Perfect pockets

Exercise:

Have your kid write a 50-style hook with simple, catchy patterns.

LESSON 6

G-Unit Era: Building an Army

Artist-development strategy:

- Tony Yayo (day-one loyalty)
- Lloyd Banks (lyricist of the crew)
- Young Buck (Southern addition, voice contrast)

Concepts of:

- loyalty

- brotherhood
- team branding

  unity in imagery (bulletproof vests, G-Unit clothing)

Listening Lab:

- **"Stunt 101"**
- **"Smile"**
- **"Beg for Mercy"**

> "How does a group amplify the leader's persona?"

LESSON 7

Beef as Marketing: The Supervillain Playbook

50 Cent didn't just argue. He used conflict as attention, confidence as armor, and humor as a weapon. Beef was marketing, not feelings... all the time.

50's feuds with:

- Ja Rule
- Fat Joe
- Jadakiss

  Game

  Rick Ross

Explain:

- How 50 baited opponents into boosting HIS visibility
- Diss tracks as brand-building
- Danger of overusing conflict

"Conflict gets attention, but strategy keeps success."

LESSON 8

Business Moves: 50 the Mogul

Teach:

- Vitamin Water deal (made $100M+)
- G-Unit clothing
- Headphones line

  Acting (Power, Get Rich or Die Tryin')

  Producing (Power Universe franchise)

  Liquor (Branson, Le Chemin du Roi)

Show that musicians become millionaires by branching out.

LESSON 9

50's Flow & Vocal Identity

His flow signatures:

- Monotone menace
- Unbothered pacing
- Nasal-but-heavy tone

Calm confidence
Storytelling with clipped delivery
Off-key melodic hums (which modern rappers like Future took cues from)

Listening Lab:

- **"Hustler's Ambition"**
- **"I Get Money"**

> "What does his VOICE make you picture?"

LESSON 10

50 Cent's Influence Tree

Influenced by 50:

Pop Smoke
21 Savage
Chief Keef (attitude/style)
Future (melodic menace)
The Game (initially)
Don Q
Tory Lanez (hooks)
Joey Badass (NY energy)
Every drill rapper with a story-to-threat cadence

Activity:

Trace 50's influence to modern drill. Teach historical continuity.

FINAL PROJECT

Explain how 50 Cent transformed rap through mixtapes, hook writing, branding, and narrative control — using ONE album, ONE mixtape, and TWO influence examples.

UNIT 10

BEYONCÉ

Beyoncé still matters because she represents evolution done right. She started as a hitmaker and grew into a cultural force without losing musical excellence. Her songs endure because they balance technical skill with emotional clarity. Every era of her music teaches something different about growth, confidence, and ownership. Kids don't need to understand all that yet. They just need to feel that greatness lasts.

PASSED DOWN TRACK

"Irreplaceable"

This song teaches strength without aggression. It's clear, confident, and timeless. Kids hear authority in her voice even if they don't know why yet. That's legacy music.

TODDLER-FRIENDLY BEYONCÉ

(CLEAN, SAFE OPTIONS)

- **"Love on Top"**
- **"Brown Skin Girl"**
- **"Before I Let Go"**
- **"Halo" (clean)**

They'll bop without the rated-R extras.

UNIT OVERVIEW

Beyoncé =

The most technically refined pop vocalist of her generation
The greatest live performer of her era
A pioneer of visual albums and surprise drops
A master of reinvention
A Black Southern woman reshaping global culture
A full creative director, not "just a singer"
A blueprint for excellence, discipline, and audiovisual storytelling

Your kid gon' learn:

- Stagecraft
- Vocal technique
- Artistic evolution
- How to honor and elevate Black culture

- The politics of pop stardom
- Perfectionism vs authenticity

LESSON 1

Destiny's Child: The Foundation of Discipline

Teach where Beyoncé came from:

- Houston roots, talent shows, early grind
- Destiny's Child lineup changes → professionalism under pressure
- Matthew Knowles' bootcamp training (vocals + choreography simultaneously)

Beyoncé's early leadership instincts

Harmonies + R&B girl group evolution

Key Tracks:

- **"Say My Name"**
- **"Survivor"**
- **"Bills, Bills, Bills"**

Activity:

Show your kid how the harmonies are structured. Teach teamwork, discipline, and resilience.

LESSON 2

Dangerously in Love: The Solo Bloom

Show Beyoncé claiming her own voice:

- Leaving a successful group without falling off
- Establishing a signature vocal identity
- Emotional range + vocal control

Pop crossover mixed with R&B roots

Beyoncé becoming a household name

Key Tracks:

- **"Crazy in Love"**
- **"Me, Myself and I"**
- **"Baby Boy"**

Listening Lab:

- the soft falsetto
- the power belt
- the talk-sing/rap-sung delivery

LESSON 3

B'Day: The Performer Emerges

Show Beyoncé stepping into her full stage persona:

- High-energy performances
- The funk influences
- Vocal athleticism

Beyoncé shaping choreography culture
Rapid-fire runs + controlled raspiness

Key Tracks:

- **"Déjà Vu"**
- **"Get Me Bodied"**
- **"Ring the Alarm"**

Activity:

Show a live performance. Ask: "How is she dancing AND singing this clean?" Teach discipline + breath control.

LESSON 4

Sasha Fierce: Duality & Branding

Introduce persona development:

- Sasha Fierce = confidence/exaggerated self
- Beyoncé = controlled, introverted, reserved
- Using alter egos to explore sound

Iconic anthems becoming cultural statements
Pop stardom transformed into empowerment language

Key Tracks:

- **"Single Ladies"**
- **"Halo"**
- **"Diva"**

> "How do artists use personas to express different sides of themselves?"

LESSON 5

BEYONCÉ (2013): The Surprise Drop Revolution

Show Beyoncé changing the industry model:

- Surprise album drop. No singles, no promo
- Visual album as standard for pop
- Mature themes: sexuality, marriage, motherhood

Confidence + vulnerability balanced
Beyoncé's full creative control moment

Key Tracks:

- **"Partition"**
- **"Drunk in Love"**
- **"Haunted"**
- **"Mine"**

Activity:

Watch 2–3 videos → discuss visual language, symbolism, choreography.

LESSON 6

LEMONADE: Black Womanhood in Cinematic Form

Teach storytelling, politics, and identity:

- Southern Black woman lineage
- Infidelity narrative + generational trauma
- Visual album structure (chapters, poetry, motifs)

Fashion as cultural symbolism

Beyoncé affirming Black beauty, spirituality, sisterhood

The political weight of putting this on a mainstream platform

Key Tracks:

- **"Pray You Catch Me"**
- **"Sorry"**
- **"Hold Up"**
- **"Freedom"**
- **"Formation"**

Activity:

Break down "Formation" imagery → teach your kid how art can protest.

LESSON 7

Homecoming: Perfectionism, HBCU Culture & Work Ethic

Teach:

- 8 months of training → 2-hour Coachella performance
- Live band, majorette, step show, HBCU style tribute
- Vocals LIVE while dancing fullout

Beyoncé as general, director, coach, and performer

Black excellence showcased on a global stage

Activity:

Compare Homecoming version of a song vs studio version. Ask: "Why do some artists sound BETTER live?"

LESSON 8

Renaissance: House, Ballroom, & Black Queer Influence

Teach genre erasure + cultural honoring:

- Beyoncé's strategic reclaiming of Black queer music roots
- House, disco, funk, ballroom, bounce
- Collaboration with queer artists, producers, DJs

Celebration, joy, and empowerment after grief (pandemic era)

Sonic experimentation without abandoning accessibility

Key Tracks:

- **"Alien Superstar"**
- **"Cuff It"**
- **"Break My Soul"**
- **"Heated"**
- **"Pure/Honey"**

> **"Black music BUILT every genre."**

LESSON 9

Bey as a Leader: Business, Branding, Discipline

Teach professionalism through her example:

- Beyoncé as CEO of Parkwood Entertainment
- Artistic ownership
- Perfectionism in rehearsals

Protecting her privacy strategically
Innovating merch, tours, visuals
The long-game approach to legacy

> "What does leadership look like when excellence is non-negotiable?"

LESSON 10

Beyoncé's Influence Tree

Vocal descendants:

Chloe Bailey
Ariana Grande
Jessie J
Jazmine Sullivan (mutual influence)

Performance descendants:

Normani
Tinashe
Victoria Monét
Doja Cat (hybrid performance model)

Cultural impact:

- Black women centering themselves in pop
- HBCU culture becoming mainstream
- Visual albums becoming normal

Surprise drops adopted industry-wide
Standard for stage production elevated permanently

Activity:

Make a family tree of influence. It'll look like Beyoncé is the root of half the 2010s–2020s.

FINAL PROJECT

Explain how Beyoncé reshaped music, performance, and Black cultural representation across three eras: Destiny's Child, Solo Pop Domination, and Visual Album Era.

BUILD YOUR OWN CRATE

Music doesn't get passed down by rules. It gets passed down by choice — and by someone deciding that a song was worth carrying forward.

Now it's your turn.

A crate is just a collection of songs that mean something to you. DJs used to haul actual crates of records from gig to gig. The weight was part of the commitment. Yours might live on a phone, a playlist, a piece of paper on the fridge. What matters is that you picked the songs, and you can tell someone why.

There's no right answer here. The goal isn't a perfect list. The goal is to start listening like someone who cares about what they're hearing.

A note for adults using this section:

Let the child lead. Resist the urge to correct their taste, improve their choices, or turn this into a history lesson. The goal isn't to raise a music critic. It's to raise a listener. If they pick a song you don't know or don't love — that's the whole point. Ask them about it.

Step 1: Pick Your Songs

Choose 3–5 songs you like right now. They can be:

- From this guide
- From your parents' music
- From something you found on your own

There are no wrong answers.

My Crate Songs:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____

Step 2: Why This One?

For each song, circle or say why you picked it: (It's okay to pick more than one.)

- It makes me want to move
- It makes me feel calm
- It makes me feel confident

It sounds cool

I don't know why yet, I just like it

Step 3: When Would You Play It?

Music has moments. Pick one for each song:

- Car ride
- Cleaning up
- Before bed

Party

When I'm sad

When I'm happy

Anytime

Step 4: Share Your Crate

Play one song from your crate for someone else. Tell them one thing about it:

- What you like
- How it makes you feel
- What it reminds you of

They don't have to agree. That's the point.

Step 5: Keep the Crate Open

Crates change over time. You can:

- Add songs
- Remove songs
- Swap songs
  Come back later and rebuild it

Music grows with you.

CLOSING: AN OPEN CRATE

This crate isn't meant to stay the same. Come back to it every year. Rebuild it as tastes change, voices deepen, and new questions show up. Some songs will stay. Some will fall out. That's growth, not disrespect. Each time you return, you're not just choosing music, you're marking time.

What starts as background noise turns into memory. A song from this crate might one day remind a child of a car ride, a living room, a season of life. That's how music becomes personal history. Not because it was assigned, but because it was lived with.

There's no finish line here. Just an open crate passed from hand to hand, year after year.

Keep it open.

Keep listening.

Keep adding to it.